ALCOHOL PERSONAL LICENCE / STUDY COURSE

Independent Level 2 APLH exam preparation - England & Wales

Important: This is educational training material, not a Home Office accreditation, awarding-body qualification, personal licence or licence to sell alcohol. An approved qualification and licensing-authority application remain necessary.

Designed for bar teams, nightclub managers, restaurant operators, karaoke venues, event staff and future Designated Premises Supervisors (DPS).

Learning plan

- Module 1 - The four objectives and licensable activities
- Module 2 - Who grants what: licences, DPS and authorisations
- Module 3 - Personal licence applications and duties
- Module 4 - Preventing underage sales and verifying ID
- Module 5 - The mandatory licensing conditions
- Module 6 - Offences, intoxication and responsible service
- Module 7 - Events, TENs and venue compliance
- Module 8 - Scenarios, revision and operating checklists
- Original 40-question mock assessment and answer key

Study approach

Read each module and discuss the venue scenario. Practise with the original 40-question assessment. Aim for at least 28/40 on this practice test. Actual accredited assessment timing and logistics depend on the provider and awarding body; verify them with your exam centre.

01 The purpose of alcohol licensing

The Licensing Act 2003 governs alcohol licensing in England and Wales. Licensing authorities must promote four equally important objectives.

- Prevention of crime and disorder: policies to deter violence, antisocial behaviour and illegal activity.
- Public safety: emergency exits, safe capacities, competent staffing, risk assessments and safe evacuation.
- Prevention of public nuisance: reduce disturbance from music, arrivals, queues and departing guests.
- Protection of children from harm: manage age verification, underage access and unsuitable exposure.
- Licensable activities include retail alcohol sale, qualifying club alcohol supply, regulated entertainment and late-night refreshment (generally 11 pm to 5 am, subject to exceptions).
- The licensing authority is usually the council. The police, fire, environmental health and trading standards are among the responsible authorities.

Venue scenario

A nearby resident complains about late-night noise. Which objective matters? Public nuisance. Review door management, queue behaviour and dispersal procedures.

02 Different permissions and responsibilities

The name on a personal licence is not a free pass to sell alcohol anywhere. The venue needs the correct permission too.

- A premises licence authorises specified licensable activities at a particular location, subject to hours and conditions.
- A personal licence authorises an individual to sell alcohol or authorise sales under a valid premises licence; it is not premises authorisation.
- Generally one DPS is named on a premises licence authorising alcohol sales; that DPS holds a personal licence.
- Other workers do not each need a personal licence if sales are authorised by a personal licence holder. Written authorisation is strongly recommended but is not itself mandatory.
- The DPS or authorising personal licence holder does not legally need to be physically present for each individual sale, but compliance responsibilities remain.
- Genuine qualifying members' clubs under a club premises certificate and TENs have different rules; avoid assuming every privately hired venue qualifies as a club.

Venue scenario

A venue has a personal licence holder but no premises permission to sell alcohol. Can it trade? No. Both the person and location framework must be lawful.

03 Applying for a personal licence

A course certificate and a council-issued personal licence are separate steps.

- Normally the applicant must be 18 or over, hold an approved licensing qualification, satisfy right-to-work rules and make a proper application.
- Apply to the licensing authority where ordinarily resident; special rules apply if not ordinarily resident in an England and Wales authority area.
- The application generally includes the required form, qualifying certificate, identity photographs, criminal-record disclosure and fee; confirm your council's instructions.
- Relevant unspent convictions or equivalent foreign offences can trigger police involvement and refusal after the statutory process.
- Personal licences generally continue without periodic renewal. They can be surrendered, suspended, revoked or invalidated for relevant reasons, including certain immigration circumstances.
- Holding a qualification alone does not make someone a DPS. The premises must nominate the person and the authority must update the premises licence.

Venue scenario

A learner passes an approved APLH examination today. Can they start calling themselves a personal licence holder? No. The licensing authority has not granted the personal licence.

04 Age restrictions and verification

Under-18 alcohol supply is a central licensing risk. Staff must understand both the law and the venue's actual written policy.

- It is generally unlawful to sell alcohol to a person under 18. A guest list or reservation is not proof of age.
- Challenge 25 is a common voluntary venue policy, not the statutory minimum age; implement the age threshold actually set in the venue policy and conditions.
- Qualifying physical proof-of-age documents must include a photo, birth date and specified security feature such as a holographic or ultraviolet mark. Examine the person and document.
- Since 15 September 2026, qualifying registered and certified Digital Verification Services (DVS) may be used where the venue opts in and meets all conditions. A screenshot or photo alone is not an authorised digital check.
- A person aged 16 or 17 may consume beer, wine or cider with a table meal if accompanied by an adult; this is not permission to buy alcohol personally.
- Train staff in refusal procedures, fake-ID indicators and avoiding discriminatory or confrontational behaviour.

Venue scenario

A 17-year-old arrives for a booked karaoke birthday with an older sibling and a photo of their passport. The booking and photo alone do not authorise a retail alcohol sale. Decline service; follow venue policy.

05 Mandatory licensing conditions

Mandatory conditions bind many premises that sell or supply alcohol. Check the current legislation and local licence conditions.

- Ban irresponsible promotions where they encourage excessive or irresponsible consumption in the prohibited ways.
- Do not dispense alcohol directly into a customer's mouth, subject to the legal exception for disability assistance.
- Provide free potable tap water on request where reasonably available to customers.
- Adopt and communicate an age-verification policy. Digital checks are optional and subject to the September 2026 legal safeguards.
- Offer specified smaller measures and make customers aware: beer/cider half-pint; still wine by the glass 125 ml; gin, rum, vodka and whisky 25 ml or 35 ml (as applicable). Exceptions can apply to pre-sealed containers.
- Do not sell alcohol below the permitted price based on duty plus VAT. The rules on offers and pricing can be technical.

Venue scenario

A menu lists 175 ml and 250 ml wine only but serves still wine by the glass. Add the required 125 ml option and communicate its availability, unless an applicable exception applies.

06 Offences and responsible alcohol service

Responsible management is more than checking IDs. Customers' condition and venue conduct matter throughout the session.

- Do not knowingly sell alcohol to a person who is drunk, or obtain alcohol for a drunk person where prohibited by law.
- Do not sell alcohol outside the authorised hours or outside the scope and conditions of the premises licence.
- Prevent violence and disorder; use proportionate refusal, escalation and safeguarding procedures.
- Brief all bar and door staff to escalate threats, suspected drink spiking, violence and medical distress promptly.
- Enforcement consequences may include prosecution, financial penalties, licence review, suspension or revocation. Specific penalties depend on the offence and current law.
- Maintain accurate incident and refusal records as good evidence of responsible management; check any conditions requiring particular logbooks.

Venue scenario

A visibly intoxicated customer demands shots after a dispute at the bar. Stop alcohol service, get a manager or security staff, de-escalate and ensure safe assistance.

07 Events, TENs and members clubs

A Temporary Event Notice (TEN) is not the same as permanently varying a premises licence.

- For a TEN, attendance must stay below 500 people at any one time including staff; the event may last up to 168 hours.
- A personal licence holder may generally submit up to 50 TENs in a calendar year; an individual without one up to 5, subject to late-TEN sublimits.
- A premises may generally have up to 15 TENs per calendar year covering no more than 21 days in total; other statutory limits apply.
- Standard TENs generally need at least 10 clear working days' notice. A late TEN has special rules; check before relying on it.
- Qualifying members' club certificates have a separate legal test, including genuinely constituted membership and club control. Calling a bar a private members club does not confer a club exemption.
- Licence conditions on music, door supervision, capacity, CCTV and alcohol service are specific to the premises: read the actual premises licence and approved plans.

Venue scenario

A promoter wants to sell alcohol to 520 people under a TEN. That exceeds the permitted attendance limit: do not rely on a TEN.

08 The shift manager's operating system

Turn the law into checkable daily actions. This section is practical training, not an additional statutory list.

- Before doors: verify authorised hours, duty manager/DPS contacts, staff alcohol authorisations, SIA deployment where required by conditions, exits, CCTV and ID procedure.
- At entry: apply the venue's admission conditions, assess age, inspect qualifying ID as needed, count occupancy and log refusals safely.
- During service: refuse underage/intoxicated sales, offer water and smaller measures, respond to incidents and track closing times.
- At close: stop sales at the authorised time, supervise dispersal, control noise and write accurate reports.
- After incidents: preserve CCTV lawfully, take concise factual statements, secure evidence, involve police/emergency services as appropriate.
- Management review: audit staff training, actual licence conditions, guest complaints, patterns of refusal and new guidance.

Venue scenario

Before a private-hire karaoke booking begins, verify that the booking agreement does not override licence conditions. Age checking, licensed hours and duty of care apply even to a private booking.

ORIGINAL PRACTICE EXAM

40 multiple-choice questions. Choose one answer A-D per question. Target: 28 correct (70%). These questions are newly written for practice; they are not an awarding body's exam paper.

Actual approved provider assessments and the official syllabus should always take priority.

01. How many statutory licensing objectives are there?

A. Two
B. Three
C. Four
D. Five

02. Which is a licensing objective?

A. Maximising alcohol revenue
B. Prevention of public nuisance
C. Reducing all business rates
D. Promoting tourism

03. Which is normally a licensable activity?

A. Selling packaged alcohol by retail
B. Selling soft drinks at 3pm
C. Serving cold sandwiches
D. Providing Wi-Fi

04. Who usually grants a premises licence?

A. The venue bartender
B. The local licensing authority
C. The landlord alone
D. An awarding body

05. A personal licence alone allows sales of alcohol:

A. Anywhere at any hour
B. Only when required premises authority exists
C. Without following any conditions
D. Only inside the holder's home

06. What does DPS stand for?

A. Daily Police Supervisor
B. Designated Premises Supervisor
C. Director of Public Safety
D. Designated Promotions Seller

07. How many DPSs can normally be named on a premises licence at one time?

A. One
B. Two
C. Five
D. Unlimited

08. Must the DPS personally pour every alcoholic drink?

A. Yes
B. No, suitably authorised staff can sell
C. Only at weekends
D. Only if wine is sold

09. Is written authorisation to sell alcohol expressly required by the Licensing Act 2003?

A. Always
B. Never possible
C. Not expressly required, but strongly recommended
D. Only for table service

10. The normal minimum age to apply for a personal licence is:

A. 16
B. 17
C. 18
D. 21

11. Passing APLH on its own makes a learner a personal licence holder:

A. True
B. False
C. Only on weekends
D. Only on licensed premises

12. An applicant normally needs which qualification?

A. An approved licensing qualification
B. A driving test
C. A security badge
D. A hygiene score

13. Personal licences currently:

A. Require annual renewal
B. Last 12 months
C. Generally do not require periodic renewal
D. Automatically cover every venue

14. For retail alcohol sales, customers normally must be at least:

A. 16
B. 17
C. 18
D. 20

15. Challenge 25 is:

A. The statutory legal minimum for any alcohol sale
B. A commonly used venue age-checking policy
C. A licence fee
D. A type of TEN

16. A qualifying physical ID should include:

A. Name only
B. Photo and birth date plus recognised security feature
C. Home address only
D. School uniform

17. A digital ID photo shown on a phone, by itself, is:

A. Automatically sufficient
B. An accredited APLH certificate
C. Not a compliant registered DVS check
D. Mandatory for all venues

18. Since September 2026, qualifying digital age verification is:

A. Mandatory for all premises
B. An optional route subject to safeguards
C. Forbidden
D. Only for nightclubs

19. Can a 17-year-old buy beer in a pub when with a parent?

A. Yes in all circumstances
B. No, purchase is still prohibited
C. Yes after 10pm
D. Yes if the parent signs a waiver

20. Which circumstance can permit a 16- or 17-year-old to consume beer?

A. Any private party
B. With a table meal accompanied by an adult
C. At any restaurant after midnight
D. With a fake ID

21. What should staff do when unsure if a customer is old enough?

A. Ignore it
B. Serve quickly
C. Apply ID policy and refuse without sufficient proof
D. Ask another guest to vouch

22. Free potable tap water should generally be:

A. Never supplied
B. Available on request where reasonably available
C. Only available with a food purchase
D. Only served after midnight

23. What is the specified small measure for still wine by the glass?

A. 75 ml
B. 100 ml
C. 125 ml
D. 300 ml

24. Which is a specified small beer/cider measure?

A. 1/4 pint
B. 1/2 pint
C. 2 pints
D. 1 litre

25. For gin, rum, vodka and whisky the small option includes:

A. 25ml or 35ml as applicable
B. Only 100ml
C. One whole bottle
D. Unlimited pours

26. Irresponsible promotions are:

A. Always required
B. Restricted by mandatory conditions
C. Only restricted for beer
D. Excluded from all licensing rules

27. Selling alcohol below the permitted price based on duty and VAT is:

A. Required
B. Prohibited
C. Allowed whenever busy
D. Required for private hire

28. Knowingly selling alcohol to someone who is drunk is:

A. Lawful
B. An alcohol-related offence
C. Compulsory
D. Only unlawful at 2 am

29. A guest list removes the need for legal age checks:

A. Yes
B. No
C. For VIP bookings only
D. For birthdays only

30. A key duty when a guest becomes aggressive is to:

A. Continue shots service
B. Ignore warning signs
C. De-escalate and protect safety
D. Lock all emergency exits

31. A TEN event can have how many people at a time including staff?

A. Fewer than 500
B. 700
C. 1000
D. Any number

32. The maximum duration of a single TEN event is:

A. 12 hours
B. 48 hours
C. 168 hours
D. 30 days

33. A personal licence holder can generally give up to how many TENs per year?

A. 5
B. 15
C. 50
D. 100

34. A person without a personal licence can generally give up to how many TENs per year?

A. 2
B. 5
C. 20
D. 50

35. A premises can generally be the subject of up to how many TENs per year?

A. 5
B. 10
C. 15
D. 60

36. What is generally the deadline for a standard TEN?

A. 1 hour
B. At least 10 clear working days
C. Whenever doors open
D. After the event

37. A private members' label automatically exempts a bar from ordinary licensing?

A. Yes
B. No
C. Only in Soho
D. Only on Saturday

38. The DPS must legally remain inside the venue every minute alcohol is sold:

A. Yes
B. No
C. Only if there are fewer than 20 people
D. Only when cocktails are served

39. A useful good-practice record after refusing alcohol service is:

A. A refusal/incident log
B. A cocktail photo
C. A staff playlist
D. A booking advert

40. Which source should staff check for local venue-specific conditions?

A. A competitor Instagram post
B. The actual premises licence and approved plan
C. A customer review
D. The menu alone

MARKING KEY & SHORT EXPLANATIONS

This answer key relates only to the original practice assessment in this pack.

01. C The Licensing Act 2003 sets out four objectives.
02. B Preventing public nuisance is one of the four objectives.
03. A Retail alcohol sale is a licensable activity.
04. B The council licensing authority normally determines premises licences.
05. B A personal licence does not itself license a location.
06. B The DPS is the designated premises supervisor.
07. A A premises licence normally specifies a single DPS.
08. B Personal licence holders can authorise alcohol sales by others.
09. C The current statutory guidance recommends written authorisation but says the Act does not mandate it.
10. C Applicants must generally be 18 or over.
11. B The council must grant the individual personal licence.
12. A An approved qualification is normally required.
13. C Periodic renewal was removed in 2015.
14. C Alcohol sales to people under 18 are generally prohibited.
15. B Challenge 25 is a venue policy, not the legal drinking age.
16. B The statutory condition refers to a photo, DOB and hologram/UV feature.
17. C Digital proof has specific registered/certified verification requirements.
18. B Eligible DVS checks may be chosen by the premises.
19. B The table-meal exception concerns consumption, not buying.
20. B The narrow meal exception applies to beer, wine or cider with an adult.
21. C Refuse unless age can be verified under the applicable policy.
22. B A mandatory licensing condition concerns potable water.
23. C 125 ml is the specified small wine measure.
24. B Half a pint is a specified smaller measure.
25. A The condition specifies 25ml or 35ml according to the premises measure.
26. B Certain promotions encouraging excessive or irresponsible drinking are prohibited.
27. B Mandatory conditions prohibit sales below duty plus VAT.
28. B Knowingly selling to a drunk person is unlawful.
29. B Bookings and guest lists do not bypass alcohol age checks.
30. C Safety, refusal, support and escalation are important.
31. A The statutory TEN threshold is fewer than 500.
32. C A TEN event may last at most 168 hours.
33. C Subject to relevant caps and exceptions, personal licence holders have a 50 limit.
34. B Generally five TENs in a calendar year.

35. C The general site limit is 15, with an aggregate day limit too.
36. B Standard TENs normally need 10 clear working days.
37. B The club must satisfy statutory criteria and hold appropriate authorisation.
38. B The DPS need not be physically present at all times.
39. A Accurate contemporaneous records help evidence responsible practice.
40. B The current premises licence and approved plan control venue-specific restrictions.

FINAL REFERENCE SHEET

Use these legal sources when validating rules and training updates. The pack reflects material checked on 19 October 2026. Always check your venue licence and the latest version of the law.

Legislation and official guidance

Licensing Act 2003 (legislation)
https://www.legislation.gov.uk/ukpga/2003/17/contents

Home Office: Section 182 guidance, September 2026
https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/explanatory-memorandum-revised-guidance-issued-under-s-182-of-licensing-act-2003

Home Office: Alcohol licensing overview
https://www.gov.uk/guidance/alcohol-licensing

Digital age checks order (SI 2026/1022)
https://www.legislation.gov.uk/uksi/2026/1022/made

Digital proof of age: September 2026 announcement
https://www.gov.uk/government/news/new-rules-pave-the-way-for-businesses-to-adopt-digital-proof-of-age-for-alcohol-sales

Temporary Event Notices
https://www.gov.uk/find-licences/temporary-events-notice

BIIAB APLH approved qualification information
https://biiab.co.uk/qualification/level-2-award-for-personal-licence-holders/

Next steps towards a genuine qualification

1. Book the Level 2 APLH assessment with an approved centre. 2. Pass the provider's accredited assessment. 3. Obtain the certificate from that awarding body/centre. 4. Apply for a personal licence with the relevant licensing authority and evidence required. 5. Await the council decision before claiming to hold a licence.

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